

Chapter 176-2

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Chen Mian met with Qiu Zimin first. At that time, Liang Shi was sitting in Chen Mian's studio, listening to the conversation between Qiu Zimin and Chen Mian through a door.

Chen Mian had no intention of selling Shen Chi's relic.

This painting was also something her teacher had passed down to her, and it held considerable sentimental value.

Moreover, people were now starting to bid for it.

Chen Mian didn't want things to escalate, so she politely declined Qiu Zimin.

But Qiu Zimin wouldn't relent: "Name your price. I want this painting."

Chen Mian said helplessly: "I'm sorry, I don't intend to sell it. If you're in this painting, there's also another person in it. To be honest with you, Ms. Zhu is also looking to buy this painting from me, but there's only one, and I personally want to keep it in my collection."

"But this is Shen Chi's painting," Qiu Zimin said.

Chen Mian nodded: "I know. It was left to me by my teacher."

Qiu Zimin paused: "You mean you're going to sell it to Zhu Mingqi?"

"No." Chen Mian replied: "I plan to keep it for my personal collection."

Qiu Zimin stared at her with considerable resentment.

But Chen Mian asked: "May I be so bold as to ask—why do you want this painting so badly?"

Qiu Zimin scoffed lightly: "If you know it's bold, why ask?"

"My teacher told me some things before." Chen Mian said: "I'm just verifying."

"What did your teacher tell you?" Qiu Zimin asked with a hint of nervousness.

Chen Mian paused briefly: "The person Teacher Shen cared about most is in this painting."

"Who?"

Chen Mian pointed to the person on the far right. Qiu Zimin's expression immediately changed. "Nonsense!"

Chen Mian shrugged: "That's what I heard. Besides, my teacher was with Teacher Shen until she passed away, so... it should have some credibility."

"Impossible." Qiu Zimin stood up. "You don't know anything. What nonsense are you spouting?"

Chen Mian made a gesture of invitation. "Believe it or not, that's up to you."

"You really won't sell?" Qiu Zimin gritted her teeth and made another offer: "Eighty million."

Chen Mian shook her head: "Not selling."

Qiu Zimin left with anger on her face, but before leaving, she turned back to look at Chen Mian. "Everything your teacher said is false."

Chen Mian: "....."

Chen Mian nodded indifferently: "Think whatever you want to think."

When Qiu Zimin left, she slammed the door with a thunderous bang.

Only then did Liang Shi come out, carefully examining the painting. She still didn't think it had eighty million yuan worth of potential.

Chen Mian smiled lightly: "Paintings need people to give them value, including artworks. It's not about how much the materials and concept are worth—what's more important is what's contained behind it."

Liang Shi barely understood.

Afterward, Chen Mian's meeting with Zhu Mingqi went the same way. Liang Shi was still hiding in the studio.

Chen Mian declined Zhu Mingqi with the same words.

After hearing it, Zhu Mingqi simply nodded and smiled gently: "No wonder your painting style is so similar to Shen Chi's. So you're her disciple."

"I was trained in Teacher Shen's lineage, but I never met her," Chen Mian said. "She would be my grandmaster."

Zhu Mingqi smiled: "But you're probably the one who learned the most like her. Very talented."

"So about this painting?" Chen Mian asked again.

"I don't need it anymore," Zhu Mingqi said. "For me, it's just a memory. It would be nice to buy it back, but it has a different meaning for you. It's fine for you to keep it in your private collection. Anyway, these memories are all in my mind—they're not something a painting can prove."

Zhu Mingqi was very kind to people. When the painting deal fell through, she said she wanted to look around Chen Mian's studio to see if there was anything else that caught her eye.

Such people were actually very friendly to contemporary painters because they would make them richer.

Rich people spending money on paintings gave painters better conditions to create.

No one would dislike that.

But because there was someone hiding in Chen Mian's studio, she was about to refuse. Unexpectedly, Liang Shi opened the door from inside and walked out.

This startled Zhu Mingqi. "Oh, there's someone else here..."

"Ms. Zhu." Liang Shi greeted her.

After seeing clearly that it was Liang Shi, Zhu Mingqi was surprised. "Ah? It's Miss Liang. You and Chen Mian... oh right, you two left together at the art museum last time. So is this also Miss Liang's home? How presumptuous of me."

"No." Liang Shi immediately denied it. "Chen Mian and I are just friends."

"Then you mentioned you were married last time?" Zhu Mingqi naturally started chatting with her.

Liang Shi nodded: "Yes, but not to Miss Chen."

Zhu Mingqi made an "oh" sound: "Sorry."

"It's fine." Liang Shi said: "I just had plans with Chen Mian, so I was waiting for her inside. If you want to look at paintings, please go ahead."

Saying this, she stepped back to Chen Mian's side. Chen Mian didn't understand her behavior.

But Liang Shi said quietly: "Make some money."

Chen Mian: "?"

Zhu Mingqi didn't think too much about it and didn't hold back either. She went into the studio and picked out a painting she liked, closing the deal at three hundred thousand.

It was originally something Chen Mian had painted for practice. The style was vastly different from her other works and didn't resemble Shen Chi's either.

But it was the most healing painting in her studio.

Zhu Mingqi remarked: "Miss Chen must have painted this full of hope. I can see love and hope in this painting."

Chen Mian was momentarily at a loss for words, not knowing how to respond.

This painting was indeed painted while thinking of Qi Jiao after she had too much to drink.

She had thought of their first meeting.

It was a very ordinary day, with sun, with wind, with crowded streets.

A young girl sat alone in her seat, tilting her head to look out the window. Originally a very gentle face, but it was full of sorrow. She suddenly turned her head, and their eyes met.

The corners of the young girl's lips lifted slightly, but there was no light in her eyes.

Later, she saw the light in her eyes.

It was painted while thinking of her smile, so the tones were very warm.

Zhu Mingqi had hit the mark completely. Chen Mian could only say awkwardly: "Mm."

Zhu Mingqi also looked at the other paintings in Chen Mian's studio and chatted with her about some of the works.

Finally, she discovered a painting turned away in the corner.

The artistic conception of this painting was also very beautiful.

In the vast snow, a girl was constantly gazing into the distance, where there was a miniaturized cluster of light and shadow that could vaguely be made out as a person.

This painting was the only one here with a name. It was called "Gazing."

It looked very bittersweet.

When Zhu Mingqi picked up this painting to admire it, Chen Mian subconsciously glanced at Liang Shi.

Zhu Mingqi said: "What is the person in this painting gazing at?"

"Gazing at her own longing," Chen Mian said.

Perhaps having found a kindred spirit, Chen Mian didn't hold back.

She went to the room next door and brought out two more paintings—one called "Chasing," one called "Letting Go."

It was clear that these three paintings were part of the same series.

At this moment, Liang Shi also understood.

The person in these paintings was Chen Mian, was Liang Wanwan, and was also the countless people who loved but couldn't have.